

Instant repair: Training hard in the sun makes the body send nutrients to muscle repair, red blood cell production and immunity before anything else. GETTYIMAGES

Vitamin C with the same meal, and keep tea and coffee an hour away on either side.

Eat your second layer of sun protection

The sunscreen still goes on. Nothing you eat replaces it. But carotenoids build a small baseline of photoprotection over several weeks, and that is worth having when you are outdoors five days a week.

Lycopene comes from cooked tomatoes, tomato puree, watermelon and papaya. Beta-carotene comes from carrots, sweet potatoes, pumpkin and drumstick leaves. Vitamin C comes from amla, guava and citrus, paired with Vitamin E from almonds and sunflower seeds, because the two regenerate each other. Green tea and coffee add polyphenols. This is a slow build, not something you apply on race morning.

Protein is the raw material

Hair is almost entirely keratin. Skin firmness depends on collagen. Both are protein, and no serum fixes a shortage of it. An athlete training five or more days a week needs 1.6 to 2.2 grams per kilogram of body weight.

More important than the total is the quality. Keratin needs cysteine and methionine, from eggs, paneer, chicken, fish, soya, sesame and pumpkin seeds. A vegetarian living on rice and dal can hit the protein target on paper and still fall short on methionine and cysteine, which is why the hair thins even though the food diary looks fine.

Do not strip the fat out

Cutting fat too aggressively shows on the face within weeks. Omega-3 fats keep the skin barrier sealed, so you lose less water through it, and they help settle the scalp inflammation behind flaking and itching. Two servings of fatty fish a week is the baseline. For a supplement, 2 to 3 grams of combined EPA and DHA a day. Walnuts and flaxseed help, but convert poorly, so most vegetarians need algal oil.

The Vitamin D irony

Some of the most deficient people I test are athletes who spend three hours a day outdoors. Indian skin carries more melanin, city air filters out UVB, most people train before eight in the morning when UVB is weak, and those who train later are covered in sunscreen. Low vitamin D shows up as diffuse hair fall and sluggish recovery. Test it, correct it, retest at 12 weeks.

Two things to stop doing

Stop taking biotin. Genuine deficiency is rare, and high-dose biotin distorts thyroid and cardiac troponin lab results. I have seen athletes sent for unnecessary heart investigations because of it. If you are taking it, stop three days before any blood test.

Stop treating post-training sugar as free. The gel or sports drink during a long ride gets used. The dessert afterwards is a different conversation. Excess sugar binds to collagen and stiffens it, and that stiffening is a large part of why some faces age faster than the calendar suggests.

What's in a training day

Before training, black coffee with a banana or

two dates, and water with electrolytes. That coffee sits far enough from your iron-containing meals not to matter. It is the cup with lunch and dinner that costs you.

Within 45 minutes of finishing, have 25 to 30 grams of protein with fruit. Whey, eggs, paneer or a soya shake with orange or amla.

Lunch is a palm-sized portion of protein, half a plate of colour with cooked tomatoes, carrots and greens, a fistful of millet or rice, and a spoonful of ghee or coconut oil.

In the evening, have a handful of nuts and seeds with curd.

Dinner: fish twice a week, finished two and a half hours before bed. Repair happens during deep sleep. Short nights undo good eating.

Small fixes by sport

Swimmers rinse and condition immediately after the pool, because chlorine strips the lipid layer from hair and skin. Cyclists, helmet straps plus salt plus friction are a real cause of hairline breakage, so wash the same day. Cricketers and footballers get the longest midday exposure, so make lunch the carotenoid-heavy meal.

And test rather than guess. Ferritin, Vitamin D, B12, TSH and zinc tell me more on one page than six months of describing symptoms.

One last thing. Hair grows roughly a centimetre a month and skin turns over in about the same time. What you see in the mirror today is a receipt for what you ate two to three months ago. Fix the plate this week, then judge it next season, not next fortnight.

